One Neighbor's Petition Helped Stop a $5 Billion Data Center

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-11-07 3 min read

In Landover, Maryland, nearly 90 acres of empty land sit where a mall once stood. Landover Mall closed in 2002. In 2024, its builder won permission to build a $5 billion data center campus there. A data center is a huge building full of computers that keep the internet running. It uses lots of water and electricity, and many use **generators** that burn **diesel** fuel. Taylor Frazier McCollum lives less than a mile away and did not want one near her home. She started a **petition** with more than 25,000 signatures. It led to protests and local pauses, called **moratoriums**, on data centers across the county. The project, set to break ground between 2026 and 2027, is now blocked. Across the country, about 500 such **moratoriums** have followed community opposition. In 2024, McCollum and her young daughter were **evicted** after her wages were cut. She spoke at county meetings and before Maryland lawmakers. Council member Wanika Fisher said the county needs development. McCollum now wants a full ban and hopes to run for office one day.

Word Treasure

petition -- A petition is a list where many people sign their names to ask for a change.
moratoriums -- Moratoriums are pauses that stop new building for a while.
evicted -- To be evicted means to be told you must leave the home where you live.
generators -- Generators are machines that make power by burning fuel.
diesel -- Diesel is a kind of fuel used to run some big machines.

Background you need

A data center is a huge building full of computers that keep the internet running, and it uses lots of water and electricity.

When people who live nearby worry that a big building will harm their homes, they can sign a petition and speak at local meetings to ask leaders to pause or stop it.

A pause like that gives the town time to think about what kind of building should go on the empty land.

Break it down

WHO: Taylor Frazier McCollum, a neighbor who lives less than a mile from the empty land, and Council member Wanika Fisher.

WHAT: McCollum started a petition with more than 25,000 signatures, which led to protests and pauses on data centers, and the data center project is now blocked.

WHERE: In Landover, Maryland, on nearly 90 acres of empty land where a mall once stood.

WHY: McCollum did not want a data center near her home, while Fisher said the county needs development.

Why it matters

It shows that people who live near a place can speak up together and help decide what gets built close to their homes and schools.

Test what you remember

1. What used to stand on the empty land in Landover?

- (A) A mall
- (B) A school
- (C) A farm
- (D) A hospital

2. What did the builder win permission to build there?

- (A) A new shopping mall
- (B) A sports stadium
- (C) A train station
- (D) A $5 billion data center campus

3. What is a data center, as described in the story?

- (A) A huge building full of computers that keep the internet running
- (B) A factory that makes phones
- (C) A hall for concerts
- (D) A place that stores books

4. How many signatures did Taylor Frazier McCollum's petition collect?

- (A) Exactly 90
- (B) About 500
- (C) Less than 100
- (D) More than 25,000

5. What is the state of the data center project now?

- (A) It has already opened
- (B) It is now blocked
- (C) It was never planned
- (D) It moved to another state

6. Who said the county needs development?

- (A) Taylor Frazier McCollum
- (B) The builder
- (C) A neighbor
- (D) Council member Wanika Fisher

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: A 4: D 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Taylor Frazier McCollum: She did not want a data center near her home and now wants a full ban on them.

2. Council member Wanika Fisher: She said the county needs development.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):